These are not official materials from How (Not) to Read the Bible. They were developed solely for use by our group's members. Please do not distribute.

Session 2 Leader Guide: Stranger Things

How (Not) to Read the Bible · College & Young Adults · Oct 16, 2026 · @Eric

Overview

Big idea: The Old Testament law was God's good gift to Israel under the Mosaic covenant, and Christians read it through Jesus, who fulfilled it.

Skeptics love to ask, "If you ignore the verse about mixed fabrics, why keep the one about sexual ethics?" Many Christians can't answer. Tonight gives students a clear, honest way to read Old Testament law that is neither "it's all outdated" nor "it all applies the same way today."

This session builds directly on Session 1. The third circle of context (the Bible's big story) does most of the work tonight.

By the end of the session, students should be able to:

1. Explain why Leviticus was given to Israel and what it was meant to do.
2. Ask four questions of any Old Testament law (below in "Teach the method").
3. Show how the New Testament itself tells us which laws carry forward and how.
4. Answer the "you're just picking and choosing" objection with grace and clarity.

Key passages for the workshop:

- Leviticus 19:1–37 (the main text)
- Mark 7:14–23 (Jesus and the food laws)
- Supporting texts: Matthew 5:17–20, Galatians 3:23–25, Romans 13:8–10, Hebrews 8:6–13

Prep checklist:

- [ ] Watch Session 2 on RightNow Media and note where Kimball explains the Bible timeline and covenant
- [ ] Read Leviticus 19 twice, and Mark 7:1–23
- [ ] Decide how you'll address tattoos (19:28) in light of your church's teaching; see the leader note in the workshop
- [ ] Print handouts, plus extras
- [ ] Bring sticky notes in three colors for the Leviticus sorting exercise
- [ ] Test the video and slides

These are not official materials from How (Not) to Read the Bible. They were developed solely for use by our group's members. Please do not distribute.

Session plan (90 minutes)

Time	Segment	Minutes	What happens
0:00	Welcome & opener	10	Recap Session 1, Jeremiah 29 homework check, "Real or Fake?" icebreaker, prayer
0:10	Video: Session 2	21	Students take notes on the handout
0:31	Video debrief	12	Whole group, 3–4 questions
0:43	Teach the method	10	The Bible timeline, the Mosaic covenant, and four questions for any Old Testament law
0:53	Exegesis workshop	27	Leviticus 19 sorting exercise (15), then Mark 7:14–23 (12)
1:20	Apply & pray	10	Practice answering the "picking and choosing" objection, preview Session 3, prayer

If you run long: do Mark 7 as a whole group instead of at tables, and leave the sorting exercise's report-back to two tables.

Opener and video debrief

Quick recap and homework check (4 min)

Ask: *"What's the one question we learned to ask every time we read a verse?"* (What's the context?) Then check the Jeremiah 29 homework: who is the "you" in 29:11, and what's the timeless truth? (God keeps his promises to his people through long seasons of waiting.) Keep it to two or three minutes.

Icebreaker: "Real or Fake?" (6 min)

Read these one at a time. Tables vote: is it really in the Bible?

1. "You shall not wear cloth of wool and linen mixed together." **Real** (Deut 22:11; compare Lev 19:19)
2. "You shall not boil a young goat in its mother's milk." **Real** (Exod 23:19)
3. "God helps those who help themselves." **Fake** (often credited to Benjamin Franklin)

These are not official materials from How (Not) to Read the Bible. They were developed solely for use by our group's members. Please do not distribute.

4. "You shall not round off the hair on your temples or mar the edges of your beard." **Real** (Lev 19:27)
5. "Cleanliness is next to godliness." **Fake** (popularized by John Wesley)
6. "You shall love your neighbor as yourself." **Real** (Lev 19:18)

Leader note: Point out that #6 and #4 are in the same chapter, nine verses apart. That's the puzzle for tonight: Jesus called one of them the second greatest commandment (Mark 12:31), and almost no Christian keeps the other. Why?

Video debrief questions (12 min)

1. **Which "strange" law from the video surprised you most? Why does it sound so odd to us?**
   - Leader note: Let them laugh a little. The strangeness is real. Then note: strangeness to *us* is a clue that we're reading something written *for* us but not *to* us (Session 1).
2. **Kimball places the law on the Bible's timeline. Where does Leviticus fall in the big story, and why does that matter?**
   - Leader note: After the Exodus, at Mount Sinai, under the covenant God made with Israel through Moses. It is before Jesus and the new covenant (Jer 31:31–34; Luke 22:20; Heb 8:6–13). Christians are not under the Mosaic covenant as a covenant, but it is still God's Word to us.
3. **What was the law *for*? Why would God give Israel rules about food, clothing, and haircuts?**
   - Leader note: To set Israel apart as a holy nation among the Canaanite peoples (Lev 18:3, 20:26), to teach them God's holiness, to provide for justice and mercy in daily life, and to point ahead to Christ (Gal 3:24; Heb 10:1).
4. **How would you respond to a friend who says, "Christians just pick and choose which verses to follow"?**
   - Leader note: Don't answer fully yet. Tell them the workshop will give them the tools, and you'll come back to this at the end.

Teach the method (10 min)

Four questions for any Old Testament law. These sit inside last week's Observe → Interpret → Apply.

1. **Who received it, and under which covenant?** (Usually Israel, under the Mosaic covenant at Sinai.)

These are not official materials from How (Not) to Read the Bible. They were developed solely for use by our group's members. Please do not distribute.

2. **What was it for, then?** (Holiness and separation from the nations, worship and sacrifice, justice in Israel's civil life, care for the poor and vulnerable.)
3. **What does the New Testament do with it?** Does the New Testament repeat it, say Christ fulfilled it, or explicitly set it aside?
4. **What does it reveal about God's unchanging character, and how does that truth shape life in Christ?**

Stress question 3. It answers the "picking and choosing" charge. We don't decide which laws carry forward. The New Testament shows us.

Two ways faithful Christians have put this together

Both views hold that all of Scripture is God's Word, that Christ fulfilled the law (Matt 5:17), and that believers are saved by grace, not law-keeping. They usually reach the same practical conclusions by different routes.

	Threefold division	Law fulfilled as a whole
The idea	The law has moral, civil, and ceremonial parts	The Mosaic law is one covenant package, fulfilled as a whole in Christ
What carries forward	Moral law (summed up in the Ten Commandments) still binds; ceremonial laws are fulfilled in Christ; civil laws expired with Israel as a nation	Christians live under "the law of Christ" (1 Cor 9:21; Gal 6:2); Old Testament commands carry forward as the New Testament takes them up and as they reflect God's character
Held by	Aquinas, Calvin, Westminster Confession, 1689 Second London Baptist Confession (ch. 19)	Many Baptist and evangelical scholars today; close to how Kimball presents the timeline
Watch out for	Leviticus itself doesn't label its laws by category, and some laws mix categories	It can sound like the Old Testament is irrelevant, which neither side believes

Leader note: You don't need to settle this debate tonight. Teach the four questions; they work under either view. If a student asks which view your church holds, it's fine to say so.

These are not official materials from How (Not) to Read the Bible. They were developed solely for use by our group's members. Please do not distribute.

Exegesis workshop

Passage 1: Leviticus 19 sorting exercise (15 min)

Have tables read Leviticus 19:1–2 aloud first. Verse 2 is the headline of the whole chapter: *"You shall be holy, for I the Lord your God am holy."*

Then give each table the ten verse references below on sticky notes. Tables look up each verse, then the New Testament cross-reference on their handout, and place it in one of three columns:

- **Repeated:** The New Testament restates it directly.
- **Fulfilled:** Christ fulfilled it, or the New Testament sets it aside.
- **Carried forward:** The principle about God's character carries forward in a new form.

Answer key (some placements are debatable, and that's useful discussion):

Leviticus 19	What it says	New Testament	Column
v. 2	Be holy, for I am holy	1 Pet 1:15–16	Repeated
vv. 9–10	Leave the edges of your field for the poor	Eph 4:28; Gal 2:10	Carried forward
vv. 11–12	Don't steal, lie, or swear falsely	Eph 4:25, 28	Repeated
v. 18	Love your neighbor as yourself	Mark 12:31; Rom 13:8–10	Repeated
v. 19	Don't mix seed or fabrics	(none)	Fulfilled
vv. 21–22	Bring a ram as a guilt offering	Heb 10:10–14	Fulfilled
vv. 27–28	Don't cut your hair or flesh for the dead; no tattoo marks	1 Cor 6:19–20; 10:31	Carried forward (debated)
v. 31	Don't turn to mediums or necromancers	Gal 5:19–21	Repeated
v. 32	Stand up before the elderly	1 Tim 5:1–2	Carried forward
vv. 33–34	Love the foreigner as yourself	Matt 25:35; Heb 13:2	Carried forward

These are not official materials from How (Not) to Read the Bible. They were developed solely for use by our group's members. Please do not distribute.

Leader commentary:

- **The chapter is mostly beautiful.** Gleaning laws, care for the deaf and blind (v. 14), fair courts (v. 15), honest weights (vv. 35–36). Students often expect Leviticus to be harsh and find it full of mercy.
- **Mixed fabrics (v. 19):** Many scholars note that mixtures of wool and linen were reserved for holy things like the tabernacle curtains and priestly garments (Exod 26:1; 28:6). Keeping kinds separate in ordinary life was a daily, visible picture of Israel's call to be set apart. That picture finds its fulfillment in Christ, who makes a holy people from every nation (1 Pet 2:9).
- **Tattoos (v. 28):** Read verses 26–31 together. The surrounding verses deal with pagan practices: divination, mourning rites for the dead, cult prostitution, and mediums. The command most likely forbade marks tied to pagan mourning or worship. Faithful Christians disagree on how this applies to tattoos today. Help students see that the question isn't settled by quoting verse 28 alone, nor by saying "that's just Old Testament." Both shortcuts skip the work. Point them to the principle that carries forward: our bodies belong to God (1 Cor 6:19–20), and we should not take on the marks of false worship. Then share your church's teaching.

Passage 2: Mark 7:14–23 (12 min)

This passage shows the New Testament itself doing what we just practiced.

What students should notice (Observe):

- The setting (7:1–5) is a dispute over ritual hand-washing.
- Jesus says nothing outside a person can defile them by going in (v. 15).
- Mark adds a comment in verse 19: *"Thus he declared all foods clean"* (ESV).
- Real defilement comes from the heart (vv. 21–23).

Leader commentary (Interpret):

The food laws (Lev 11) were real commands from God for Israel. They marked Israel off from the nations and taught that God cares about purity. Jesus doesn't call them a mistake. He shows what they pointed to: God wants a clean heart, and only he can give one. Acts 10:9–16, 28 then shows the next step. Peter's vision about food is really about people: Gentiles are now welcome in God's family without becoming Jews.

Timeless truth: God requires holiness of heart, not just outward rule-keeping, and Jesus makes unclean people clean.

These are not official materials from How (Not) to Read the Bible. They were developed solely for use by our group's members. Please do not distribute.

Discussion prompt: *If the food laws pointed to something, what were they pointing to? How does that change how you read Leviticus 11?*

Apply, field questions, and pray

Practice the answer (6 min)

Pair students up. One plays a skeptical friend: *"You ignore the mixed-fabric verse, so why should anyone listen to you about anything else in Leviticus?"* The other answers using the four questions. Switch after two minutes.

A good answer sounds something like: *"I'm not picking and choosing. Those laws were given to Israel under a specific covenant. Jesus fulfilled that covenant, and the New Testament itself tells us which commands carry forward. Loving my neighbor is repeated; the fabric law was a picture of holiness that pointed to Christ."*

Questions students are likely to ask

"Isn't it inconsistent to keep Leviticus 18's sexual ethics but not Leviticus 19:19?" No. Run both through question 3. The New Testament restates the sexual ethics (Rom 1:26–27; 1 Cor 6:9–11) and roots them in creation (Gen 2:24; Matt 19:4–6), before Sinai. The fabric law is never restated and was part of Israel's distinctive identity. Answer with grace: 1 Corinthians 6:11 ("such were some of you") holds out hope to everyone.

"Are the Ten Commandments still binding?" Nine are clearly restated in the New Testament. Christians differ on how the Sabbath command applies, and many see it fulfilled in Christ's rest (Heb 4:9–10) and reflected in gathering on the Lord's Day.

"If we're not under the law, why read Leviticus at all?" Because it's God's Word, written for our instruction (Rom 15:4; 1 Cor 10:11; 2 Tim 3:16–17). Hebrews can't be understood without it, and it shows us the holiness of God and how costly sin is, which makes the cross make sense.

"Does this mean the Old Testament God is different from Jesus?" No. Same God, same holiness, same love. Leviticus 19:18 is in the "strange" book, and Jesus quotes it. That theme returns in Sessions 5 and 6.

These are not official materials from How (Not) to Read the Bible. They were developed solely for use by our group's members. Please do not distribute.

Preview Session 3

Next week: *Boys' Club Christianity*. What does the Bible say about women? Ask students to read 1 Timothy 2 and 1 Corinthians 14 before they come, and to bring their honest questions.

Closing prayer

Pray Leviticus 19:2 and 1 Peter 1:15–16: thank God that he is holy, and that in Christ he makes us holy.